

Suncus megalura

Forest musk shrew



Length 2–2½ in (5–7 cm)
Tail 3–3½ in (8–9 cm)
Weight ¾ oz (5 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location W., E., C., and southern Africa



This species is shrewlike in most respects, although it has a relatively long, streamlined body, large and prominent ears, and a tail longer than its head and body. Its soft, velvety fur is brown on the upperparts and almost white on the belly. It hunts in soil, leaf litter, and among branches (using its tail to balance) for invertebrates. The forest musk shrew is probably active in bursts through the day and night, and must eat almost its own body weight in food every 24 hours.

Nectogale elegans

Tibetan water shrew



Length 3½–5 in (9–13 cm)
Tail 3–4¼ in (8–11 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location S. Asia



A small, wary, secretive inhabitant of cold, fast mountain streams in the Himalayas and nearby mountains, this tubby, semiaquatic shrew is slate-gray on the upperparts and silvery white beneath. Its snout is blunt, its eyes and ears tiny, and its black tail is fringed by rows of hairs along each side. It probably eats water insects, fish fry, and other small prey, carrying them to a bank or a midstream rock for consumption. Little is known of its nesting or breeding habits.

Diplomesodon pulchellum

Piebald shrew



Length 2–2½ in (5–7 cm)
Tail ¾–1¼ in (2–3 cm)
Weight ¼–7/16 oz (7–13 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location C. Asia



This species derives its name from its coloration: gray upperparts with a distinct oval white patch in the middle of the back, and white



underparts, feet, and tail. It has a very pointed snout and long whiskers, even for a shrew. Active at night, when the desert habitat is cooler and prey such as insects and small lizards become more energetic, it hunts mainly on the surface but may also dig in loose sand for grubs and worms. The average litter size is 5, with several litters in a good year.

Scutisorex somereni

Armored shrew



Length 4–6 in (10–15 cm)
Tail 2¼–3¼ in (6.5–9.5 cm)
Weight 2½–4 oz (70–125 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location C. to E. Africa



This large, woolly coated shrew, also known as the hero shrew, has a distinctively arched and tremendously strong back. This is



gray fur

because its vertebrae have interlocking flanges, or spines, not only along their sides, as in other mammals, but also above and below. The armored shrew is solitary, and is a skillful climber. Its diet consists of worms, insects, spiders, and carrion.

Crocidura leucodon

Bicolored white-toothed shrew



Length 1½–7 in (4–18 cm)
Tail 1½–4¼ in (4–11 cm)
Weight 7/32–7/16 oz (6–13 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location Europe to W. Asia



Sharp demarcation between its gray-white upperparts and whitish yellow underside give this



shrew its common name. It also has long, thick whiskers (vibrissae) on its sharp-pointed snout, and a bicolored tail that is less than half the length of the head and body. This adaptable forager in grassland, scrub, wood edge, parks, and gardens eats worms, grubs, and other small invertebrates, hunting mainly by night but also for short periods by daylight. Like similar shrew species, it builds a nest of dry grass in a hole or thick undergrowth. The male produces strong scents from glands on his flanks during the breeding season, generally March to October. Gestation is 31 days, average litter size is 4, and weaning occurs after 26 days.

Desmana moschata

Russian desman



Length 7–8½ in (18–21 cm)
Tail 7–8½ in (17–21 cm)
Weight 16 oz (450 g)
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable

Location E. Europe to C. Asia



Desmans belong to the mole family, but resemble water shrews. The tail is as long as the head and body, and flattened from side to side for use as both a paddle and a rudder. The rear feet are fully webbed to the toe tips, the front feet partly so. Using its long, sensitive nose, it probes by night for prey in riverbed mud and stones. Unusually for an insectivore, the desman lives in groups and several may share a bank burrow. After 40–50 days' gestation, the 3–5 young are cared for by the female, and weaned by 4 weeks.

CONSERVATION

In addition to being harmed by pollution, the Russian desman faces a new threat: ultrafine plastic nets, which are used for fishing in rivers and lakes. The nets pose a hazard long after they are discarded, by entangling and drowning desmans when they dive. Conservation measures include reintroductions to places where numbers are low, and legal restrictions to limit net use.



OUTER AND INNER COATS

The soft, dense underfur of the Russian desman is covered by long, coarse guard hairs, the coat being rich brown on the head and body, fading to ash-gray on the underside.



Galemys pyrenaicus

Pyrenean desman



Length 5 in (12.5 cm)
Tail 5½ in (14 cm)
Weight 17/16–1¾ oz (40–50 g)
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Vulnerable

Location S.W. Europe



The Pyrenean desman generally resembles the only other species of desman (see right), although it is smaller, takes lesser prey, such as the aquatic larvae of mayflies and stoneflies, and is more suited to fast-flowing streams. Its

long, black snout is almost hairless, its thick fur brown above and silvery below, and its tail slightly flattened from side to side like a rudder. A male and a female may form a loose pair bond, with the male chasing away rivals and the female nesting in a bank burrow, but little more is known of these mammals.

